HAN IS ON A POLITICAL HUNT

sets off a storm of speculation—suitors line up before the Muslim satrap, the SP watches edgily









HIS OWN DURBAR Akhilesh visits Azam; right, from top: Swami Prasad Maurya, Chandrashekhar Azad, Mayawati are among suitors

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bad times. After stepping out, he seemed to take a veiled swipe at Akhilesh, who did not go to receive him. "If I was truly a big leader, another big leader would have come to meet me," he said, in the tones of a potential mutineer.

OUTWARD HO?

The way Akhilesh has run his party, there isn't much space for such claims of equivalence. So, is Khan planning to leave the SP? "Ask those who are making these assumptions," replies the man. "I couldn't meet anyone in jail and was also not allowed to make phone calls." Cryptic words that ensured his intentions were open to interpretation.

Thus opens up a political space of much interest. Several political figures have been reaching out to Khan, eager to mend fences or win favour. Many speculate he could part ways with the SP to join the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) or Chandrashekhar Azad's Azad Samaj Party. Azad had met him in jail and later visited his family in Rampur.

Any lateral mobility on his part could unsettle equations in western UP, where his influence has endured through his prison years. The BSP option has drawn particular attention. Though Mayawati trashes all talk of secret meetings, saying she "does not meet anyone on the sly", Khan has added to the intrigue by repeatedly praising her in recent statements.

Akhilesh bought an insurance policy against any calamity by striking a conciliatory note. Prompt in welcoming Khan's release, he said the veteran had "fought alongside the party founder against the BJP" and that once the SP was back in power, "all false cases against him will be withdrawn." Over a week later, the two finally met in person, with Akhilesh flying to Rampur for a two-hour closed-door meeting.

MEETING TIME

The optics were well managed. Khan received him; they travelled in one car; Akhilesh claimed all differences had been resolved. But Khan's subsequent remarks—"we have to decide who is mine and who is not, I need some time for that"—left the door ajar.

Joining the flurry of well-wishers, ex-minister and Apni Janta Party president Swami Prasad Maurya, too, made a "courtesy visit" to Rampur. His line was clear. "There was not even a single protest by the SP for Azam Khan. It's as responsible as the BJP for the atrocities against him," Maurya said.

Curiously, after pursuing over 70 criminal cases against Khan, from land grab to hate speech—and taking two cases to conviction to put him out of action—the state government too seems softer. It has restored Khan's Y-category security, a gesture many are trying to parse. It's a thick fog of intrigue that hovers over Rampur. ■

Takeaways

- **After two years in jail, SP's Muslim satrap Azam Khan returns like a twister in UP politics**
- **Uneasy ties with SP chief Akhilesh make him open to options: BSP is a popular bet**